

SUPREME COURT OF THE STATE OF NEW YORK
COUNTY OF KINGS

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DENNIS HUFF,

SUMMONS

Plaintiff,

Index No.:

-against-

The Basis of Venue is:
Location of Incident

THE CITY OF NEW YORK, NYPD POLICE OFFICER
CHRISTOPHER CAPIZZO, Shield No. 19891, and
NYPD POLICE OFFICERS JOHN DOES NUMBERS
ONE THROUGH TEN,

Plaintiff designates Kings
County as the place of trial.

Defendants.

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To the above named Defendants:

You are hereby summoned to answer the Verified Complaint in this action, and to serve a copy of your Verified Answer to the Verified Complaint, or, if the Verified Complaint is not served with this Summons, to serve a notice of appearance on the Plaintiff's attorneys within twenty days after the service of this Summons, exclusive of the day of service, where service is made by delivery upon you personally within the state, or, within 30 days after completion of service where service is made in any other manner. In case of your failure to appear or answer, judgment will be taken against you by default for the relief demanded in the complaint.

DATED: New York, New York
May 10, 2022

Yours, etc.

David Kline

David Kline, Esq.
Shulman-Hill, PLLC
Attorneys for Plaintiff
1 State Street Plaza
15th Floor
New York, New York 10004
(212) 221-1000

TO: THE CITY OF NEW YORK, Corporation Counsel, 100 Church Street, NY, NY 10007

NYPD POLICE OFFICER CHRISTOPHER CAPIZZO, Shield No. 19891, Housing PSA-
1; 2860 West 23rd Street, Brooklyn, NY 11224

SUPREME COURT OF THE STATE OF NEW YORK
COUNTY OF KINGS

----- X

DENNIS HUFF,

INDEX NO.:

Plaintiff,

VERIFIED COMPLAINT

-against-

THE CITY OF NEW YORK, NYPD POLICE OFFICER
CHRISTOPHER CAPIZZO, Shield No. 19891, and
NYPD POLICE OFFICERS JOHN DOES NUMBERS
ONE THROUGH TEN,

JURY TRIAL DEMANDED

Defendants.

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Plaintiff DENNIS HUFF, by his attorneys, Shulman-Hill, PLLC, as and for his Verified Complaint herein, alleges upon information and belief as follows:

PRELIMINARY STATEMENT

1. This is a civil rights action to recover money damages arising out of defendants' violation of Plaintiff's rights as secured by the Civil Rights Act, 42 U.S.C. Sections 1983 and 1988, and of rights secured by the Fourth, Fifth, and Fourteenth Amendments to the United States Constitution, and the common law and the laws of the State of New York. On February 12, 2021, at approximately 4:30 p.m., Plaintiff Dennis Huff, while lawfully in the vicinity of 2352 West 8th Street, County of Kings, New York, was subject to an unlawful arrest, detention, and excessive use of force by defendant Police Officers. In addition, Plaintiff was subjected to excessively tight handcuffs which caused injury to his hands and wrists. Plaintiff was deprived of his constitutional, common law, and statutory rights when the individual defendants unlawfully stopped, detained, subjected to excessive force, passed along false accusations to prosecuting attorneys and engaged in the malicious prosecution of Plaintiff, in violation of the Fourth, Fifth, and Fourteenth Amendments to the United States Constitution, the common law and the laws of the State of New York.

PARTIES

2. Plaintiff Dennis Huff is a resident of the state of New York.

3. NYPD Police Officer Christopher Capizzo, Shield No. 19891, is and was at all times relevant herein an Officer with the New York City Police Department.

4. NYPD Police Officer Christopher Capizzo, Shield No. 19891, is being sued in his individual and official capacity.

5. Currently and at all times relevant herein, NYPD Police Officer Christopher Capizzo, Shield No. 19891, was assigned to the Housing PSA-1 Police Precinct of the NYPD.

6. NYPD Police Officers John Does Numbers One through ten are and were at all times relevant herein officers, employees, and agents of the New York City Police Department.

7. NYPD Police Officers John Does Numbers One through ten are being sued in their individual and official capacities.

8. At all times relevant herein, the individual defendants were acting under color of state law in the course and scope of their duties and functions as agents, servants, employees and officers of the New York City Police Department, and otherwise performed and engaged in conduct incidental to the performance of their lawful functions in the course of their duties. They were acting for and on behalf of the New York City Police Department at all times relevant herein, with the power and authority vested in them as officers, agents and employees of the New York City Police Department and incidental to the lawful pursuit of their duties as officers, employees and agents of the New York City Police Department.

9. Defendant City of New York is a municipal entity created and authorized under the laws of the State of New York. It is authorized by law to maintain a police department, which acts as its agent in the area of law enforcement and for which it is ultimately responsible. The defendant City of New York assumes the risks incidental to the maintenance of a police force and the employment of police officers as said risks attach to the public consumers of the services provided by the New York City Police Department.

10. Plaintiff in furtherance of his causes of action brought pursuant to New York State law filed a timely Notice of Claim against the City of New York in compliance with the Municipal Law Section 50 and in accordance with New York State law.

11. In accordance with New York State law and General Municipal Law Section 50, Plaintiff testified at a hearing held pursuant to General Municipal Law Section 50-H on March 15, 2022.

12. More than thirty (30) days have elapsed since service of said Notice of Claim was filed and the City of New York has failed to pay or adjust the claims.

13. This action falls within one or more of the exceptions as set forth in CPLR Section 1602, involving intentional actions, as well as the defendant, and/or defendants, having acted in reckless disregard for the safety of others, as well as having performed intentional acts.

14. Plaintiff has sustained damages in an amount in excess of the jurisdictional limits of all the lower Courts of the State of New York.

STATEMENT OF FACTS

15. On February 12, 2021, at approximately 4:30 p.m., Plaintiff was present in the vicinity of 2352 West 8th Street, County of Kings, New York, when the defendant Police Officers unlawfully arrested Plaintiff without probable cause or legal justification.

16. On the day of the relevant incident, Plaintiff had been to the store to pick up some food for his family and was coming home to his apartment building, located at 2352 West 8th Street in Brooklyn, New York.

17. Upon approaching his building, the Plaintiff observed approximately five (5) unmarked police vehicles parked outside, with blue lights on.

18. Plaintiff proceeded to enter the building and saw several defendant officers congregating in the hallway.

19. As Plaintiff continued toward his apartment, the defendant officers asked the plaintiff where he was going.

20. When the plaintiff responded that he was headed to his apartment, several defendant officers grabbed the plaintiff and slammed him into a wall.

21. It was at this point that the defendant officers began to arrest the plaintiff, tightly restraining him with metal handcuffs.

22. At no time relevant herein did Plaintiff commit a crime or violate the law in any way, nor did the police officers have an objective reason to accuse Plaintiff of committing a crime or violating the law in any way.

23. At no point did Defendant Officers recover any drugs, weapons, graffiti instruments, or other illegal contraband from Plaintiff or from a location that was in Plaintiff's possession, custody, or control.

24. Plaintiff did not resist arrest.

25. Nevertheless, Plaintiff was unlawfully arrested and handcuffed by the defendant officers without legal justification or probable cause, placed in the back of an NYPD van, and transported to the Housing PSA-1 Precinct against his will.

26. Upon his arrival at the Precinct, the Plaintiff was unlawfully fingerprinted, photographed, subjected to pat-down search, and placed in a holding cell.

27. After a short time at the precinct, the Plaintiff was transported to Kings County Central Bookings where he was fingerprinted, searched, and placed in another holding cell.

28. While en route to Central Bookings, the plaintiff complained to defendant officers that his handcuffs were too tight and he was in pain, but Plaintiff was ignored.

29. While Plaintiff was in custody, the defendant police officers provided the Kings County District Attorney's Office with the false, misleading, and/or incomplete information that Plaintiff committed a crime.

30. Specifically, the defendant police officers falsely stated to the Kings County District Attorney's Office that Plaintiff was engaged in Obstructing Governmental Administration.

31. After approximately 24 hours in custody, the plaintiff appeared in criminal court, was charged with crimes he did not commit, and was released on his own recognizance.

32. On or about September 28, 2021, all charges against the plaintiff were ordered to be dismissed and sealed.

33. As a result of the excessively tight handcuffs, the plaintiff suffered injuries to his wrists and hands.

34. Some of the police officer defendants observed the violation of Plaintiff's rights under the Constitution of the United States and New York State Law and did nothing to prevent their fellow officers from unjustifiably arresting, confining, and using excessive force against Plaintiff.

35. The unlawful arrest, confinement, and use of excessive force by the individually named defendants caused Plaintiff to sustain physical, psychological and emotional trauma.

FIRST CAUSE OF ACTION

Negligence

36. The Plaintiff repeats, reiterates, and realleges each and every allegation contained in the foregoing paragraphs with the same force and effect as if more fully set forth at length herein.

37. Defendants owed a duty of care to Plaintiff.

38. To the extent defendants claim that the injuries to Plaintiff by the defendant police officers were unintentionally caused and that the force used by the defendants against him was unintentional, then the defendants breached that duty of care by, among other things, tightly handcuffing him and slamming him into a wall.

39. As a direct and proximate result of such acts, defendants deprived Plaintiff of his rights under the laws of the State of New York.

40. All of the foregoing occurred without any fault or provocation by Plaintiff.

41. Defendants were at all times agents, servants, and employees acting within the scope of their employment by the City of New York and the New York City Police Department, which are therefore responsible for their conduct.

42. The City, as the employer of the officer defendants, is responsible for their wrongdoing under the doctrine of *respondeat superior*.

43. As a result of the aforementioned conduct of defendants, Plaintiff sustained injuries, including but not limited to physical, emotional, and psychological injuries.

SECOND CAUSE OF ACTION

Unlawful Stop, Question, and Search

44. The Plaintiff repeats, reiterates, and realleges the foregoing paragraphs as if the same were fully set forth at length herein.

45. The illegal approach, pursuit, stop and grab employed by defendants herein terminated Plaintiff's freedom of movement through means intentionally applied.

46. The conduct of defendants in approaching, stopping, and grabbing Plaintiff was performed under color of law and without any reasonable suspicion of criminality or other constitutionally required grounds.

47. As a direct and proximate result of such acts, defendants deprived Plaintiff of his rights under the laws of the State of New York.

48. Defendants were at all times agents, servants, and employees acting within the scope of their employment by the City of New York and the New York City Police Department, which are therefore responsible for their conduct.

49. The City, as the employer of the officer defendants, is responsible for their wrongdoing under the doctrine of *respondeat superior*.

THIRD CAUSE OF ACTION

Violation of Fourth and Fourteenth Amendment Rights:

Unlawful Seizure and Deprivation of Liberty

50. The Plaintiff repeats, reiterates, and realleges the foregoing paragraphs as if the same were fully set forth at length herein.

51. The individually named police officer defendants, while acting in concert and within the scope of their authority, caused Plaintiff to be seized, unlawfully searched, falsely

arrested, falsely imprisoned, and maliciously prosecuted without reasonable suspicion and/or probable cause, in violation of Plaintiff's right to be free of an unreasonable seizure under the Fourth Amendment of the Constitution of the United States and to be free of a deprivation of liberty under the Fourteenth Amendment to the Constitution of the United States.

52. As a result of the aforementioned conduct of defendants, Plaintiff sustained injuries, including but not limited to physical, emotional, and psychological injuries.

FOURTH CAUSE OF ACTION

False Imprisonment

53. The Plaintiff repeats, reiterates, and realleges the foregoing paragraphs as if the same were fully set forth at length herein.

54. The acts and conduct of the defendants constitute false arrest and false imprisonment under the laws of the State of New York. Defendants intended to confine Plaintiff and, in fact, confined Plaintiff, and Plaintiff was conscious of the confinement. In addition, Plaintiff did not consent to the confinement and the confinement was not otherwise privileged.

55. As a direct and proximate result of such acts, defendants deprived Plaintiff of his rights under the laws of the State of New York and the United States Constitution.

56. Defendants were at all times agents, servants, and employees acting within the scope of their employment by the City of New York and the New York City Police Department, which are therefore responsible for their conduct.

57. The City, as the employer of the officer defendants, is responsible for their wrongdoing under the doctrine of *respondeat superior*.

58. As a result of the aforementioned conduct of defendants, Plaintiff sustained injuries, including but not limited to loss of liberty, emotional and psychological injuries.

FIFTH CAUSE OF ACTION

Violation of Plaintiff's Fourth And Fourteenth Amendment Rights: Excessive Force

59. The Plaintiff repeats, reiterates, and realleges each and every allegation contained in the foregoing paragraphs with the same force and effect as if more fully set forth at length herein.

60. The use of excessive force by defendants by, amongst other things, slamming him into a wall and tightly handcuffing him, constituted objectively unreasonable physical seizures of Plaintiff in violation of his rights under the Fourth and Fourteenth Amendments to the Constitution of the United States and to be free of a deprivation of liberty under the Fourteenth Amendment to the Constitution of the United States.

61. Defendants were at all times agents, servants, and employees acting within the scope of his employment by the City of New York and the New York City Police Department, which are therefore responsible for their conduct.

SIXTH CAUSE OF ACTION
Negligent Infliction of Emotional Distress

62. The Plaintiff repeats, reiterates, and realleges each and every allegation contained in the foregoing paragraphs with the same force and effect as if more fully set forth at length herein.

63. By the actions described herein, defendants, each acting individually and in concert with each other, engaged in extreme and outrageous conduct, conduct utterly intolerable in a civilized community, which negligently caused severe emotional distress to Plaintiff.

64. The acts and conduct of the defendants were the direct and proximate cause of injury and damage to Plaintiff and violated Plaintiff's statutory and common law rights as guaranteed Plaintiff by the laws and Constitution of the State of New York.

65. As a direct and proximate result of such acts, defendants deprived Plaintiff of his rights under the laws of the State of New York.

66. Defendants were at all times agents, servants, and employees acting within the scope of their employment by the City of New York and the New York City Police Department, which are therefore responsible for their conduct.

67. The City, as the employer of the officer defendants, is responsible for their wrongdoing under the doctrine of *respondeat superior*.

68. As a result of the aforementioned conduct of defendants, Plaintiff sustained injuries, including but not limited to emotional and psychological injuries.

SEVENTH CAUSE OF ACTION
Negligent Hiring, Retention, Training and Supervision

69. The Plaintiff repeats, reiterates, and realleges each and every allegation contained in the foregoing paragraphs with the same force and effect as if more fully set forth at length herein.

70. The City of New York and its employees, servants and/or agents acting within the scope of their employment did negligently hire, retain, train and supervise defendants, individuals who were unfit for the performance of police duties on the aforementioned dates at the aforementioned locations.

71. As a result of the aforementioned conduct of defendants, Plaintiff sustained injuries, including but not limited to physical, emotional, and psychological injuries.

EIGHTH CAUSE OF ACTION

Failure to Intervene

72. The Plaintiff repeats, reiterates, and realleges each and every allegation contained in the foregoing paragraphs with the same force and effect as if more fully set forth at length herein.

73. The defendants that did not physically touch Plaintiff, but were present when other officers violated Plaintiff's Constitutional Rights had an affirmative duty to intervene on behalf of Plaintiff, whose constitutional rights were being violated in their presence by other officers.

74. Defendants failed to intervene to prevent the unlawful conduct described herein.

75. As a result of the foregoing, Plaintiff suffered serious injury, his liberty was restricted for an extended period of time, he was put in fear for his safety, and he was humiliated and subject to other physical constraints.

76. As a direct and proximate result of such acts, defendants deprived Plaintiff of his rights under the laws of the State of New York.

77. Defendants were at all times agents, servants, and employees acting within the scope of their employment by the City of New York and the New York City Police Department, which are therefore responsible for their conduct.

78. The City, as the employer of the officer defendants, is responsible for their wrongdoing under the doctrine of *respondeat superior*.

79. As a result of the aforementioned conduct of defendants, Plaintiff sustained injuries, including but not limited to emotional and psychological injuries.

NINTH CAUSE OF ACTION

Violation of Fourth And Fourteenth Amendment Rights:

Denial of Right to Fair Trial/Due Process

80. The Plaintiff repeats, reiterates, and realleges the foregoing paragraphs as if the same were fully set forth at length herein.

81. Defendants, individually and collectively, manufactured and/or withheld false evidence and forwarded this false evidence to prosecutors in the Kings County District Attorney's Office.

82. Defendants filled out false and misleading police reports and forwarded them to prosecutors in the Kings County District Attorney's Office.

83. Defendants signed false and misleading criminal court affidavits and forwarded them to prosecutors in the Kings County District Attorney's Office.

84. In withholding/creating false evidence against Plaintiff, and in providing/withholding information with respect thereto, Defendants violated Plaintiff's constitutional right to due process and fair trial under the New York State Constitution and under the Due Process Clause of the Fifth Amendment to the Constitution of the United States and to be free to deprivation of liberty under the Fourteenth Amendment to the United States Constitution.

85. As a result of the foregoing, Plaintiff sustained, inter alia, loss of the right to due process and a fair trial, loss of liberty, emotional distress, embarrassment and humiliation, and deprivation of his constitutional rights.

86. Defendants were at all times agents, servants, and employees acting within the scope of their employment by the City of New York and the New York City Police Department, which are therefore responsible for their conduct.

87. The City, as the employer of the officer Defendants, is responsible for their wrongdoing under the doctrine of *respondeat superior*.

88. As a result of the aforementioned conduct of Defendants, Plaintiff sustained injuries including, but not limited to: economic, emotional, and psychological injuries.

TENTH CAUSE OF ACTION **Malicious Prosecution**

89. The Plaintiff repeats, reiterates, and realleges the foregoing paragraphs as if the same were fully set forth at length herein.

90. The acts and conduct of the Defendants constitute malicious prosecution under the United States Constitution.

91. Defendants commenced and continued a criminal proceeding against Plaintiff.

92. There was actual malice and an absence of probable cause for the criminal proceeding against Plaintiff and for each of the charges for which he was prosecuted.

93. The prosecution and criminal proceedings terminated in Plaintiff's favor on the aforementioned dates.

JURY DEMAND

94. Plaintiff hereby demands trial by jury of all issues properly triable thereby.

PRAYER FOR RELIEF

WHEREFORE, Plaintiff DENNIS HUFF demands judgment against the defendants on each cause of action in amounts to be determined upon the trial of this action which exceeds the jurisdiction of lower courts, inclusive of punitive damages and attorneys' fees inclusive of costs and disbursements of this action, interest and such other relief as is appropriate under the law, and that the Plaintiff recover the cost of the suit herein, including reasonable attorney's fees pursuant to 42 U.S.C. § 1988.

Dated: New York, New York
May 10, 2022

By: David Kline
David Kline, Esq.
Shulman-Hill, PLLC
Attorneys for Plaintiff
1 State Street Plaza
15th Floor
New York, New York 10004
(212) 221-1000

TO: THE CITY OF NEW YORK, Corporation Counsel, 100 Church Street, NY, NY 10007

NYPD POLICE OFFICER CHRISTOPHER CAPIZZO, Shield No. 19891, Housing
PSA-1; 2860 West 23rd Street, Brooklyn, NY 11224

ATTORNEY'S VERIFICATION

DAVID KLINE, an attorney duly admitted to practice before the Courts of the

State of New York, affirms the following to be true under the penalties of perjury:

I am a partner of the law firm of **SHULMAN-HILL PLLC**, I have read the annexed **VERIFIED COMPLAINT** and know the contents thereof, and the same are true to my knowledge, except those matters therein which are stated to be alleged upon information and belief, and as to those matters I believe them to be true. My belief, as to those matters therein not stated upon knowledge, is based upon facts, records, and other pertinent information contained in my files. The reason this verification is made by me and not Plaintiff is because Plaintiff does not reside in the county wherein I maintain my office.

DATED: New York, New York
May 10, 2022

David Kline
DAVID KLINE, ESQ.